

Vest of Tools Introduction
SOPHIE MAK-SCHRAM

How do we learn together? What can we learn from each other? Amidst the rise of continued urgencies (war, fascism, poverty, the climate crisis), education and activism are increasingly the concern of local communities, who might be experiencing their access to learning restricted, their resources limited, large influxes of people in need arriving, or their prior ways of living as now impossible. In Poland, for instance, the war in Ukraine incited many cultural institutions, local centres and individuals to design, with great speed and generosity, means of accommodating those arriving into the country. These collective actions were often very localised – collaborating with venues, resources, individuals with spare rooms or language skills – but also translocally networked, as solidarity groups shared information, sometimes funds, and, less commonly, rebuttals to the narratives being peddled on a state or European level. In the wake of state oversight and failures, initiatives such as these provided essential services whilst simultaneously developing the infrastructure and resources to do so. So too, on a different timeline, one can think of LGBTQI+ activist groups and their alternative schools, spaces and programmes that blend community building, activism, and creativity.

En1 These groups often respond to specific contexts and communities, whilst also

operating translocally in terms of their alliances and impact. In Warsaw, they operate within a context of conservatism and contradictory visibility: Vogue can put up posters celebrating Pride Month, but they are subsequently defaced, same-sex marriage is not possible and abortion remains illegal.

The Vest of Tools seeks to draw on the learning that occurs within and through these forms of collective work, that happens in specific localities, contexts and communities. From negotiating ways of living together through to how to organise marches and protests, collectives often develop specific strategies and methods for this mutual learning. These strategies are necessary, sometimes even urgent, for enabling conversation, mobilisation, bringing in further groups or participants, and for sustaining group-centred work that attempts to be equitable or long-term.

Given that these strategies are often developed intuitively and in specific relation to context and time, how might they become learning catalysts for other groups, or become operational in other local settings?

The Vest of Tools (Warsaw) is a collection of these strategies, specific to a number of collectives that were active in Warsaw in the summer of 2022. Each collective works with groups in some form, and in so doing, ‘does’ something. They were invited to reflect on what strategies or methods are specific to their practice that enables them to do so;

En2 how do they do what they do? The tools in the pockets of this vest offer you a

way to try out, play with or adapt their techniques for learning together, and perhaps be translocally inspired to adopt or amend tools that you can use in your collective practice(s).

The tools
LOCAL IS THE NEW GLOBAL
BY OPEN PLACE

Open Place redeveloped an activity they first devised for a project in Somerset, UK, more than a decade ago. This activity draws forward their core learnings from 20 years of working together with others in public space; that successful projects effectively consider the three components of people, place and problem. Open Place often works in different locales that are not necessarily their own, including, due to the current invasion of Ukraine, Warsaw. To do so, they have developed a practice of bringing people and their input in, in part via activities such as Local is the New Global. Local is the New Global is based on Open Place’s activity, but modified to allow you to run the activity without their facilitating presence. It also expands on their existing practice, in allowing you to complete the process in any order and add new categories in; an expansion that emerged through conversation on how to best allow for creativity within the framework of a structured activity. Congruent with their wider practice, Open Place are keen to collect the different ways in which Local is the New Global is

En3 played - so do archive, share and negotiate with them when you use this tool.

CHANT FOR BREAD, CHANT FOR ROSES
BY KOLEKTYW ŁASKI

Kolektyw Łaski’s feminist practice is rooted in an understanding that popular culture shapes socio-cultural realities. To change our reality, we need to change our current song - sometimes, quite literally. Kolektyw Łaski work with groups to rewrite nationalist, traditional and popular song lyrics, produce new songbooks and throw playful karaoke sessions to sing these new chants. In conversation, they reflected on the importance of both identifying the right song for your specific context, and having a setting - be it a stage, a loudspeaker or a microphone - that would give you the confidence to claim the power to re-sing it. For the Vest of Tools, they’ve equipped you with your own microphone, complete with a starting chant that is at once a method for rewriting your own problematic cultural lyrics and a warm up song you can use with your group to begin a session or march.

MAGNIFYING MIRRORING GLASS
BY ZAKOLE

To think with ZAKOLE, is to step into the wetland together. Their practice is entangled with the species, climate and reality of the site they take their name and purpose from. So entangled, even, that they too leave traces as they conduct their research: this tool takes its inspiration from a practice that is as much pragmatic as it is conceptual – the magnifying glasses they frequently lose, share

En4 and find anew in the swamp. Zooming

in was a key trope of our conversations on their practice. Taking from the experiences and methodologies collectively developed at the wetland they invite you to look at the layers of inhabitation of a feral site while practising attunement to different scales. The process of enlarging makes an object more intimate and imaginable, and perhaps brings you closer to its own perspective. This magnifying mirroring glass offers you a way to explore your surroundings with new focus while staying aware of your own presence and position within them.

IMPROVISATION DICE
BY SŁOŃ NA WOLI

Słoń is a special place: playfulness abounds. Occasionally framed as led by artist Pamela Bożek in collaboration with Vera Ganzha and Anna Ilchuk, Słoń’s central focus is the group of the day, whoever is present, but community creation happens with and through the ones who stay for longer. Given that change and collective play are such core features of the way those at Słoń spend time together, identifying a single tool or method consistent across their work took several experiments. They tried out a few activities, from which the idea of the dice emerged. Rather than having an individual shift or change the activity, you can use a die. Dice were not used at Słoń regularly, but allow you, outside of their specific space, to borrow an element of their improvisational prowess and playfully continue to

En5 play together.

Contributors
OPEN PLACE

Open Place is an artistic initiative. Its primary objective is to facilitate discussions and exchange opinions, ideas and experiences between artists, curators and various social groups from across Ukraine and other countries. The platform aims to hold meetings, conduct joint actions and propose possible prospects for the development of art, politics and socio-cultural transition. Open Place supports interdisciplinary projects aimed at expanding the understanding of art and attracting new groups of people to the creative process. Open Place brings together the experiences of Ukrainian and foreign colleagues in working with public spaces, and in participatory practices and strategies for attracting various social groups.

KOLEKTYW ŁASKI

Kolektyw Łaski (“Grace Collective”) is Julia Golachowska, Jagoda Kwiatkowska and Anna Shimomura: a group of female artists, who met at the Academy of Fine Arts in Warsaw. They are friends and share the need to collectively create socially-engaged art. Their work revolves around history, memory, gender, feminism, ecology and identity. They work with language and voice, using well-known songs as a tool of social change. They believe in sisterhood and the effectiveness of art. In their first project “The New Patriotic Songbook”,

En6 they rewrote the lyrics of patriotic songs, changing misogynist, racist, classist and

pro-war fragments into feminist, pacifist, inclusive and community-empowering content. Since 2018, this project has been presented at more than twenty exhibitions and events in the country.

ZAKOLE

ZAKOLE is a project rooted in a wetland located near the heart of Warsaw. The Zakole Wawerskie (Wawer Meander) area consists of mostly inaccessible marsh and vast meadows. Its inhabitants are a variety of creatures: beavers, birds, frogs, mosquitoes, alders, reeds, grasses, and people. Our goal is to explore Zakole Wawerskie, its inhabitants and visitors, and to identify and map its various meanings. We search for ways of telling the stories of such areas and experiencing them as well as foregrounding the perspective of the creatures forming their complex ecosystems. We find it crucial to highlight the significance of similar sites in cities, primarily for the reasons of biodiversity and climate, while focussing on the complexity of relations and interests of various actors. In order to get to know Zakole Wawerskie better, we have developed a variety of observational methods, which make it easier to approach its ecosystem. We organized intimate gatherings to exchange experiences, information and thoughts about Zakole and similar places, which offered an opportunity to reflect on our capacity of understanding other organisms and the networks of dependencies they

En7 build. We also sought answers to this question by conducting experimental

walks with groups of artists and biologists, during which we practiced attunement to non-human entities. Activities within the ZAKOLE project create possibilities of generating and exchanging various kinds of knowledge: historical and scientific as well as personal, embodied and based on sensory experience. We also gather information about administrative proceedings concerning Zakole Wawerskie and potential scenarios for the future of the area, while constantly asking ourselves how to think about the multispecies right to the city.

zakole.pl/en

SŁOŃ NA WOLI

Słoń na Woli is a place for meetings and games based on educational artistic activities, curated by artist Pamela Bożek, who works with people involved in the migration and refugee crisis on a daily basis, and collaborators Vera Ganzha and Anna Ilchuk.Started in Warsaw after Russia attacked Ukraine, Bożek opened a space in Zachęta Museum for both children and adults. After this, the team moved to Wolskie Centrum Kultury and became Słoń na Woli. Refugees (mostly from Ukraine) could come and stay for the day. This created a community between people who were together from March until August, who stayed in touch after. A final exhibition of the participating children’s artworks took place at Wolskie Centrum Kultury in August. The project was possible thanks

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KAJA KUSZTRA, GRAPHIC DESIGNER

Kaja Kusztra is a Warsaw based designer and artist. She teaches Visual Communication at Kraków Academy of Fine Arts and is a member of Warsaw Museum of Modern Art’s “SUNFLOWER” SOLIDARY COMMUNITY CENTER. Her practice often examines the possible alternatives to the idea of leadership.

PLANETA KUZ, COSTUME DESIGNER

Planeta (1996) was born in Kyiv, UA. Since 2013 she has lived and worked in Poland. She is a trans-media artist and performer whose practice is based on a symbiotic view of life. Researcher of queer erotica, a practitioner of shamanism. Returning to ceremonial traditions and learning the process of rituals based on shamanic practices, she explores the world of complex and intermingled relationships as the most profound form of eroticism. Using objects from the second circulation, she creates costumes and scenography for her ceremonies and performances. She’s looking for new forms of communication with Nature, an alternative fetish through performance.

MATYLDA DOBROWOLSKA, PRODUCER

Matylda graduated in art history at the Faculty of Visual Culture Management at the Academy of Fine Arts in Warsaw. She has been associated with the Bęc Zmiana Foundation, Krzak Cooperative and

En9 Biennale Warszawa. She coordinates projects, conferences, exhibitions,

workshops, discussions, and the promotion and production of books and magazines. Matylda is currently associated with the Museum of Warsaw.

SOPHIE MAK-SCHRAM
CONCEPT & CREATIVE INTERLOCUTOR

Sophie Mak-Schram (she/her) is an art historian, producer, educator and occasional practitioner. She likes to think-work-make-be with other people around knowledges constituted through art, and what political, social and cultural implications these knowledges (can) have. She has been, amongst other things, one founding half of Overheard Map, an annual residency project that experiments with how artists work together, one half of Tail Bend Travel, a (sometimes fictional) tour company that offers new ways of exploring your localities, one part of Cera Project, a curatorial platform for art of the non-West, and one part of PACTO, an international art collective. She also designs educational programmes aimed at fostering social activism and community building internationally, and enjoys curating workshops and residencies for emerging artists. Her current research (in part held through the academic frame of a PhD) thinks alongside contemporary alternative educational projects about how these pedagogical propositions enact new political futures. The project Vest of Tools exists within the framework of this research, and is part of Sophie’s wider interest in the socialisation of learning and knowing, and how

En10 groups come together.

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En11

INSTRUCTIONS En1	ZAKOLE Magnifying Mirror Glass This little tool is for you to spend some time with. See how it feels in your hand. Open it up to look closely and carefully at something or someone of a scale different than your own. See through the scale from which the image emerges. Think about the existing or possible relationship between yourself and what you see. Take your time, give them time. Use the mirror as a reminder of your position in space and a way of relating to the observed. En5
Open Place Local is the New Global Local is the New Global allows participants to explore the localities they find themselves (living) in. The cards invite you to collectively learn about your shared context and discuss its values, to create outlines of projects for implementation in the public sphere, or to feed natural curiosity and dream up possible scenarios together. This set is designed for 5 people to use at once. If you have a bigger group, please prepare additional cards: 3 cards of each colour (yellow, blue, red, green, orange) for each additional player. The cards in this envelope can be used for different purposes: En2	Słoń na Woli Dice What do we want to do today? This dice captures a key element of Słoń’s approach to being together: improvisation. It is made from the most popular textile we use at Słoń* to sew toys with the children who are the majority of our group. It reminds most of the group of real elephant colours and skin texture somehow, which is what our group/center is named after. And, we just liked it. The dice is hand-made with the help of a sewing machine. Sewing is also one of the most popular activities at ‘Słoń na Woli’. We sew a lot of toys together, often En6
for example, when you need additional cards, or when you would like to add new categories of card to your deck (e.g. adding the category ‘aim’ or ‘obstacle’). You can adapt the game to suit your aims or needs: you can use it to map your locality and its resources, come up with creative or community-specific solutions to problems, or to playfully imagine ways to bring groups together. If you would like to share your results, feelings, or propositions of how to improve Local is the New Global, please email info@openplace.com.ua En3	based on drawings made by the children. The games on the dice were chosen by the children and workers of Słoń: they are our top 5 favourite activities that we do together. Instructions: roll the dice to pick what a group will play next. If you roll the empty side, you can choose to roll the die again, or choose the activity of ‘doing nothing’ for the next 30 minutes. Doing nothing is also a creative thing to do together sometimes! En7
KOLEKTYW ŁASKI Instruction: (1) Scan code from the pocket to see the lyrics of the song. (2) Take the microphone out of your pocket. (3) Press and hold the button on the top to activate the microphone - a blue LED will light up. (4) Turn on background music with the PLAY button in the center. (5) Sing! And if you don’t feel like it, just use the microphone as a speaker - you can already hear the polyphony in the recording (6) Borrow other known melodies and give them a new meaning. En4	(1) table game ‘Memory’: a game we’re sure you know already too – can you find the pairs? You might need to find a deck of cards or make your own. (2)museums: we love (playing in) museums at Słoń. Find your nearest museum and go for a visit. (3) lunch: maybe it’s time to eat together. Are you hungry? What can we turn into a picnic? (4) playground: find your nearest playground, preferably outdoors. Use or imagine the equipment to run around & and make noise in. (5) Drawing: find a piece of paper and a pen or pencil. Draw what’s in your head? (6) *empty side: roll again, or choose to do nothing together for the next 30 minutes En8

